

Linux terminal

Laboratórios de Sistemas e Serviços

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Command Line

Welcome to the Command Line!

The **Terminal** is your direct, text-based connection to the operating system.

- **Why use it?**

- **Power & Speed:** Execute complex tasks instantly.
- **Automation:** Script repetitive jobs.
- **Efficiency:** Uses minimal system resources.
- **Industry Standard:** Essential for developers and system administrators.

Analogy: A GUI is a restaurant menu. The CLI is speaking directly to the chef.

The **shell** is the program that interprets your commands. The terminal is the window; the shell is the brain inside.

- There are many shells, each with different features:
 - `sh` (Bourne Shell): The original, classic shell.
 - `zsh` (Z Shell): A popular modern shell with extensive customization.
 - `fish` (Friendly Interactive Shell): Focuses on being user-friendly out of the box.
 - `bash` (Bourne Again SHell): The most common shell on Linux. It's the de facto standard we will learn today.

Linux Filesystem

Linux Filesystem: Core Directories

The filesystem is a tree starting from the **root (/)**.

- **/**: The **root directory**. Everything begins here.
- **/home**: Your personal files are here (e.g., **/home/student**).
- **/bin**: Essential user **binaries** (programs like **ls**).
- **/etc**: System-wide **configuration** files.
- **/var**: **Variable** data, like system logs (**/var/log**).
- **/tmp**: For **temporary** files.

More important locations you'll encounter.

- `/opt`: **Optional** software. Used by third-party programs you install manually (e.g., Google Chrome).
- `/usr/local`: A place for software you compile or install for all users that isn't part of the standard OS distribution. You'll often find `/usr/local/bin`.
- `/root`: The home directory for the **superuser** (root user). Do not confuse this with the `/root` directory!

Visualizing the Filesystem Tree i

Unlike Windows (which uses C:\, D:\), Linux uses a single unified tree starting at /.

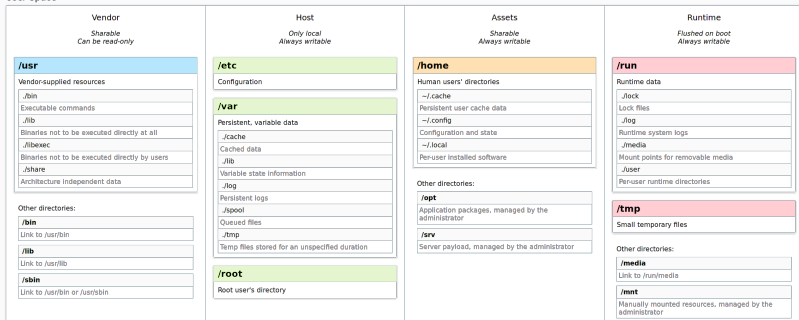
```
/ (Root)
├── bin (Binaries/Programs)
├── etc (Configuration)
├── home (User Personal Files)
│   ├── student
│   │   ├── Documents
│   │   └── Downloads
└── var (Logs and Variable Data)
```


Visualizing the path: /home/student/Documents

1. Start at Root /
2. Go into home
3. Go into student
4. You are in Documents

Visualizing the Filesystem Tree ii

User Space



Kernel Space



Sources : [man file.hierarchy\(7\)](#) & [man udisks\(8\)](#).

Figure 1: Modern Linux FHS

Hidden Files & Directories

In your home directory (~), many configuration files are “hidden” by starting with a dot (.). They control how your programs and shell behave.

- **Examples:**

- `~/.bashrc`: Bash shell configuration script. This is a crucial file.
- `~/.config`: A common directory for application settings.
- `~/.themes` or `~/.local/share/themes`: For desktop themes.
- `~/.gitconfig`: Your Git configuration.

Absolute vs. Relative Paths

Understanding your “address” in the filesystem tree is vital for navigation.

- **Absolute Paths:** Always start from the **root (/)**.
 - Example: `/home/student/Documents`.
 - Works no matter where you currently are in the system.
- **Relative Paths:** Start from your **current working directory**.
 - Example: If you are in `/home/student`, the relative path to `Documents` is just `Documents`.
 - `..` (Double dot) represents the parent directory (one level up).
 - `.` (Single dot) represents the current directory itself.

Basic navigation

Basic Navigation: pwd and cd

Two fundamental commands for moving around.

- **pwd: Print Working Directory.** Shows your current location.

```
$ pwd  
/home/student
```

- **cd: Change Directory.** Moves you to an absolute or relative path.

```
$ cd /var/log      # Move to an absolute path  
$ cd Documents     # Move to a subdirectory
```

Special Navigation Shortcuts with `cd`

`cd` has several useful shortcuts for faster navigation.

- Move up one level:

```
$ cd ..
```

- Go directly to your home directory from anywhere:

```
$ cd ~
```

(Or just `cd` with no arguments)

- Go back to the last directory you were in:

```
$ cd -
```

The Magic Key: Tab Completion i

The **Tab** key is your best friend in the terminal.

- **Auto-complete:** Type the first few letters of a command or filename and press Tab. The shell will finish typing it for you.
- **Avoid Typos:** If it doesn't complete, you might have a spelling mistake.
- **List Options:** Press Tab **twice** to see a list of all matching files or commands.

The Magic Key: Tab Completion ii

Example: To enter Documents, just type `cd Doc` and press Tab.

```
$ cd Doc<TAB>
```

```
# Becomes:
```

```
$ cd Documents/
```

Listing Directory Contents: `ls`

The `ls` command **lists** the contents of a directory. It's your eyes in the terminal.

- Use **flags** to change its behavior. The most common is `-l` for a **long** list format.

```
$ ls -l
-rw-r--r-- 1 student student 4096 \
Sep 19 2025 my_doc.txt
drwxr-xr-x 2 student student 4096 \
Sep 17 2025 Scripts
```

- This shows permissions, owner, size, and modification date.

Seeing Everything with `ls -a`

How do we see those hidden configuration files?

- The `-a` flag tells `ls` to show **a**ll files.

```
$ ls -a
.  ..  .bashrc  .profile  Documents  Downloads
```

- You can combine flags. `ls -la` is a very common command to get a **l**ong list of **a**ll files.

Create Folders/Files

Creating Directories: `mkdir`

Use the `mkdir` command to **make** a new **directory**.

- **Create a single directory:**

```
$ mkdir my_project
```

- **Create a nested structure:** The `-p` (**p**arents) flag creates the entire directory path, even if the parent directories don't exist yet.

```
$ mkdir -p Documents/Work/2025/Reports
```

Viewing File Contents: cat, less, head

You don't always need an editor (nano) just to read a file.

- **cat**: Dumps the **entire** file content to the screen. Good for short files.

```
$ cat /etc/hostname
```

- **less**: Opens a scrollable viewer. **Essential for long files!**
 - Press q to quit.
 - Use Arrow Keys to scroll.

```
$ less /var/log/syslog
```

- **head**: View just the first few lines of a file.

```
$ head -n 5 system.log
```

Creating & Editing Files: touch & nano

Once you have directories, you need files to put in them.

- **touch:** The fastest way to create a new, empty file.

```
$ touch my_notes.txt
```

- **nano:** A simple, friendly terminal-based text editor.

```
$ nano my_notes.txt
```

- Type your text directly into the window.
- Press **Ctrl+X** to exit.
- Press **Y** to confirm you want to save, then **Enter**.

The Pro Editor: Vim

While nano is great for beginners, Vim (Vi IMproved) is a powerful industry standard.

- It is available on almost every Linux server and is designed for speed without leaving the home row of your keyboard.
- **Modal Editing:** Vim has different “modes”:
- **Normal Mode:** For navigation and commands (default).
- **Insert Mode:** For typing text (Press `i`).
- **Command Mode:** For saving/quitting (Press `:`).
- **The Exit Strategy:** To save and quit, press Esc, type `:wq`, and press Enter. To quit without saving, use `:q!`.

File Operations: cp, mv, and rm

Once you can create files, you need to know how to manage their lifecycle.

- **cp (Copy):** Creates a duplicate of a file or directory.
 - `$ cp file.txt backup.txt`
 - Use `-r` to copy directories recursively.
- **mv (Move/Rename):** Moves a file to a new location or renames it.
 - `$ mv old_name.txt new_name.txt` (Rename)
 - `$ mv file.txt Documents/` (Move)
- **rm (Remove):** Deletes files or directories.
 - **Warning:** There is no “Trash” bin in the terminal; deletion is permanent.
 - Use `rm -r` to delete a folder and all its contents.

Getting User & System Information

Getting System Information

The terminal is excellent for quickly checking system status.

- `whoami`: Shows your current username.
- `date`: Shows the current date and time.
- `uname -a`: Shows kernel and system info.
- `top`: Shows running processes in real-time (like Task Manager). Press `q` to quit.

Real-time Processes: htop

While `top` is the default, `htop` provides a much more user-friendly, color-coded, and interactive interface.

- **Visual Bars:** See CPU usage per core, memory usage, and swap at a glance.
- **Interactivity:** Scroll vertically and horizontally; kill processes (*F9*) without typing PIDs.
- **Search/Filter:** Easily find specific processes (*F3* or *F4*).

```
$ sudo apt install htop # If not installed
$ htop
```

Hardware Deep-Dive: dmidecode

dmidecode dumps a computer's DMI (SMBIOS) table contents into a human-readable format.

- **Hardware Info:** Provides details about BIOS, serial numbers, RAM speeds, and motherboard slots.
- **Privilege:** Requires sudo because it reads system memory.

Common Usage:

```
# Get specific info about the system (e.g., memory)
$ sudo dmidecode -t memory
# Get the system serial number
$ sudo dmidecode -s system-serial-number
```

The CPU through the Filesystem: /proc/cpuinfo

In Linux, “everything is a file.” The /proc directory is a virtual filesystem that acts as a window into the kernel.

- /proc/cpuinfo: contains the detailed parameters of your processor.

```
# View your CPU model, cores, and cache size
$ cat /proc/cpuinfo | grep "model name"
$ cat /proc/cpuinfo | grep "cpu MHz"
```

Memory and Swap: free

To get a quick snapshot of how your RAM and Swap space are being utilized, use the `free` command.

- **-h Flag:** Displays values in **human-readable** format (GB, MB) instead of bytes.
- **Swap:** This is “virtual memory” on your disk used when physical RAM is full.

```
$ free -h
      total    used    free shared buff/cache available
Mem:   30Gi   10Gi   2.6Gi   606Mi       18Gi       19Gi
Swap:  4.0Gi   768Ki   4.0Gi
```

- **buff/cache:** Memory used by the kernel for optimization; it is released if applications need it.

Users: Standard vs. Superuser

Linux is a multi-user system.

- **Standard User** (student): Your day-to-day account with limited privileges.
- **Superuser** (root): The administrator. Has complete power over the system.

To run one command with root privileges, use `sudo` (**S**uper**u**ser **d**o).

```
# This needs admin rights, so we use sudo
$ sudo apt update
```


As an administrator, you can manage user accounts from the command line.

- `sudo useradd new_user`: Creates a new user.
- `sudo passwd new_user`: Sets the password for the new user.
- `sudo userdel new_user`: Deletes a user.

File Permissions

Understanding File Permissions i

The `ls -l` command shows permissions as a 10-character string like `-rwxr-xr--`.

- **It's read in groups:** Type | Owner | Group | Others
- **r**: Permission to **read** the file.
- **w**: Permission to **write** (modify) the file.
- **x**: Permission to **execute** the file (run as a program).

Understanding File Permissions ii

Binary	Octal	String Representation	Permissions
000	0 (0+0+0)	---	No Permission
001	1 (0+0+1)	--x	Execute
010	2 (0+2+0)	-w-	Write
011	3 (0+2+1)	-wx	Write + Execute
100	4 (4+0+0)	r--	Read
101	5 (4+0+1)	r-x	Read + Execute
110	6 (4+2+0)	rw-	Read + Write
111	7 (4+2+1)	rwX	Read + Write + Execute

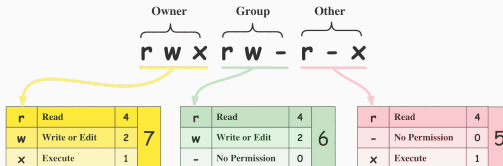


Figure 2: File Permissions

Managing Permissions with chmod

Use the chmod (**change mode**) command to change permissions.

- You can add (+) or remove (-) permissions for the **u**ser, **g**roup, or **o**thers.

Example: Make a script executable for yourself.

```
# Give the user (u) the execute (x) permission
$ chmod u+x my_script.sh
```

Package Manager

What is a Package Manager?

A package manager is a tool that automates the process of installing, updating, and removing software.

- It handles **dependencies** automatically, so you don't have to install required libraries manually.
- It keeps a database of installed software, making it easy to manage.
- For Debian and Ubuntu-based systems, the primary package manager is **APT** (Advanced Package Tool).

Analogy: Think of `apt` as an App Store for your terminal.

Updating Package Lists (apt update)

Before you install or search for anything, you should synchronize your local package list with the central software repositories.

- This command **does not** upgrade your software. It just downloads the latest list of what's available.
- This is a privileged operation, so it requires sudo.

```
# Downloads the latest package information  
$ sudo apt update
```


Searching for Packages (apt search)

If you're not sure of the exact name of a program, you can search for it.

- This command searches the names and descriptions of all available packages.
- You don't need sudo to search.

Example: Search for a program that shows system processes, like `htop`.

```
$ apt search htop
```

Installing Packages (apt install)

Once you know the package name, you can install it.

- apt will automatically download and install the program and any dependencies it needs to run.
- This requires sudo.

Example: Install the htop utility, an interactive process viewer.

```
$ sudo apt install htop
```

After installation, you can run the program by simply typing htop.

Removing Packages (apt remove / apt purge)

Removing software is just as easy as installing it. You have two main options:

1. `apt remove`: Uninstalls the program but leaves its configuration files behind (useful if you plan to reinstall it later).
2. `apt purge`: Uninstalls the program **and** deletes all of its configuration files.

Examples:

```
# Remove htop but keep its config files
```

```
$ sudo apt remove htop
```

```
# Remove htop and all of its config files
```

```
$ sudo apt purge htop
```

Cron & Crontab

`cron` is a system daemon (a background process) that runs scheduled tasks. These scheduled tasks are known as “**cron jobs.**”

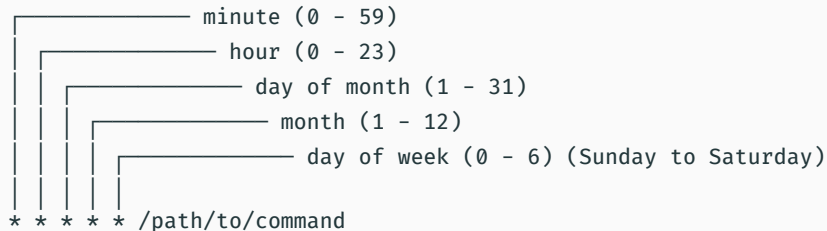
- It's the standard tool for automating repetitive tasks on a schedule.
- You manage your personal list of cron jobs using the `crontab` command.

Common Uses:

- Running a backup script every night.
- Performing system maintenance, like a weekly **ZFS scrub** or a daily **SSD trim**.
- Cleaning up temporary files.

Understanding crontab Syntax

A cron job consists of two parts: the **schedule** and the **command**. The schedule is defined by five fields, often represented by asterisks (*).



minute (0 - 59)
hour (0 - 23)
day of month (1 - 31)
month (1 - 12)
day of week (0 - 6) (Sunday to Saturday)

* * * * * /path/to/command

Understanding crontab Syntax ii

An asterisk * means “every.” For example, an asterisk in the “hour” field means “every hour.”

For an easy way to generate the correct time string, check out: crontab.guru

Managing Your crontab

You can edit, view, and remove your cron jobs with the `crontab` command and a flag.

- `crontab -e`: **Edit** your crontab file. The first time you run this, it will ask you to choose a text editor (like nano).
- `crontab -l`: **List** your currently scheduled cron jobs.
- `crontab -r`: **Remove** your entire crontab file (use with caution!).

Here are some practical examples you might add using `crontab -e`.

Example 1: Run a backup script every day at 3:30 AM.

```
# Minute Hour Day(M) Month Day(W) Command
30 3 * * * /home/student/scripts/backup.sh
```

Example 2: Run a system maintenance command every Sunday at 4:00 AM. This example is for a system command like a ZFS storage pool scrub.

```
# Minute Hour Day(M) Month Day(W) Command
0 4 * * 0 /usr/sbin/zpool scrub my-storage-pool
```

Example 3: Check disk space every 15 minutes and log the output. The >> appends the output to a log file, and 2>&1 ensures that errors are also logged.

```
# Minute Hour Day(M) Month Day(W) Command
*/15 * * * * /usr/bin/df -h >> \
/home/student/logs/disk_space.log 2>&1
```

Advanced Bash & Scripts

Redirection: Saving Output with >

Don't want to see output on the screen? Save it to a file with >.

Warning: This **overwrites** the file if it already exists.

Example: Save a list of your home directory contents to a file.

```
$ ls -l ~ > my_files.txt
```

Redirection: Appending Output with >>

To **add** output to the end of a file without deleting its contents, use >>.

- This is great for creating log files.

Example: Add a timestamped entry to a log file.

```
$ echo "System rebooted at $(date)" >> system.log
```

The Power of the Pipe |

The **pipe** is one of the most powerful concepts in the shell. It sends the output of one command to be the input of the next.

Think of it as plumbing: Command A -> | -> Command B

Example: Find all `.log` files in a directory.

```
# The output of 'ls' is "piped" to  
# 'grep' to be filtered.  
$ ls /var/log | grep .log
```

I/O Streams: Stdin, Stdout, and Stderr

Every command in Linux uses three standard data streams.

- **stdin (0):** Standard Input. Usually your keyboard.
- **stdout (1):** Standard Output. Usually your screen.
 - Redirect with `>` (overwrite) or `>>` (append).
- **stderr (2):** Standard Error. Where error messages are sent.
 - You can redirect errors separately: `command 2> errors.log`.
- **Combining them:** To save both output and errors to one file, use `2>&1`.
 - `$ ./script.sh > all_output.log 2>&1`

Your Environment: Variables

The shell uses variables to store information. By convention, they are in ALL_CAPS.

- \$HOME: Your home directory.
- \$USER: Your username.
- \$PATH: A list of directories where the shell looks for programs.

Example: See the contents of the \$PATH variable.

```
$ echo $PATH
/usr/local/sbin:/usr/local/bin:\
/usr/sbin:/usr/bin:/sbin:/bin
```


Customizing Your Shell: .bashrc

The `~/.bashrc` file is a script that runs every time you open a new terminal. This is the place to personalize your shell.

You can edit it with a text editor:

```
$ nano ~/.bashrc
```

Remember: Changes won't apply until you open a new terminal or run `source ~/.bashrc`.

Wildcards (Globbing)

Wildcards allow you to select groups of files based on patterns.

- *** (Asterisk):** Matches **any** number of characters (including zero).
 - *.txt: All files ending in .txt.
 - data_*: All files starting with data_.
- **? (Question Mark):** Matches exactly **one** character.
 - file?.txt: Matches file1.txt, fileA.txt, but *not* file10.txt.

Example: List all JPG images.

```
$ ls *.jpg
```

Customization Example: Aliases

An **alias** is a shortcut or nickname for a longer command. They save you a lot of typing!

- Add this line to your `~/ .bashrc` file:

```
alias ll='ls -aLF'
```

- Now, when you type `ll` in a new terminal, bash will run `ls -aLF` for you.

Introduction to Bash Scripting

A script is simply a text file containing a sequence of commands.

1. The first line **must** be `#!/bin/bash`. This is called a "shebang."
2. Add your commands.
3. Use `#` for comments to explain your code.
4. Make the file executable with `chmod +x`.

Scripting Example 1: Hello World

This script uses a variable and the echo command. It's the "Hello, World!" of scripting.

File: hello.sh

```
#!/bin/bash
# A simple hello world script

NAME="Student"
echo "Hello, $NAME!"
```

To run it:

```
$ chmod +x hello.sh
$ ./hello.sh
```

Scripting Example 2: Using if

This script uses an `if` statement to check if a file exists before trying to use it.

File: `check_file.sh`

```
#!/bin/bash
# Checks for the existence of the system log file.

FILENAME="/var/log/syslog"

if [ -f "$FILENAME" ]; then
    echo "$FILENAME exists."
    # We could now do something with the file, e.g.
    # tail -n 5 "$FILENAME"
else
    echo "Warning: $FILENAME not found."
fi
```

Scripting Example 3: Looping Over Files

A for loop lets you perform an action on a list of items, like files.

File: add_prefix.sh

```
#!/bin/bash
# Adds "backup_" prefix to all .txt files.
for file in *.txt
do
    # Check if it's a file before moving it
    if [ -f "$file" ]; then
        mv -- "$file" "backup_$file"
        echo "→ backup_$file"
    fi
done
echo "Batch rename complete."
```

Scripting Example 4: Complex Script

```
#!/bin/bash
# Backs up specified items into a .tar.gz archive.
# Exit if no arguments are provided.
if [ "$#" -eq 0 ]; then
    echo "Usage: $0 <file1> <dir1> ..."
    exit 1
fi
DEST="$HOME/backups"
TIME=$(date +%Y-%m-%d_%H%M%S)
ARCHIVE="$DEST/$TIME-backup.tar.gz"
mkdir -p "$DEST" # Create backup dir if needed
echo "Creating archive ..."
# "$@" holds all command-line arguments.
tar -czf "$ARCHIVE" "$@"
echo "Backup complete: $ARCHIVE"
```


Scripting Example 4: Automating System Reports

You can combine system information commands into a single Bash script for easy reporting.

File: sys_report.sh

```
#!/bin/bash
# Automates the collection of system data into a report

REPORT_FILE="system_report_$(date +%Y%m%d).txt"

echo "--- LINUX SYSTEM REPORT ---" > "$REPORT_FILE"
echo "Generated on: $(date)" >> "$REPORT_FILE"
echo "User: $(whoami)" >> "$REPORT_FILE"

echo -e "\n[CPU INFO]" >> "$REPORT_FILE"
grep "model name" /proc/cpuinfo | head -n 1 >> "$REPORT_FILE"

echo -e "\n[MEMORY USAGE]" >> "$REPORT_FILE"
free -h >> "$REPORT_FILE"

echo -e "\n[DISK SPACE]" >> "$REPORT_FILE"
```

You've now seen the core concepts of the Linux command line:

- **Navigating** the filesystem.
- **Managing** files, permissions, and users.
- **Combining** commands with pipes and redirection.
- **Automating** tasks with shell scripts.

Now, let's apply this knowledge in the practical part of the class.

Bookmark these pages. They are incredibly useful references.

- **Linux Terminal Cheat Sheet:**

<https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/linux-unix/linux-commands-cheat-sheet/>

- **Bash Cheat Sheet:**

<https://github.com/RehanSaeed/Bash-Cheat-Sheet>

- **Bash Scripting Cheat Sheet:**

<https://developers.redhat.com/cheat-sheets/bash-shell-cheat-sheet>